

Signs that the LTTE was losing ground became evident when major political parties in Tamil Nadu, led by the ruling DMK, protested against "human rights violations" of Tamils in Sri Lanka demanding a ceasefire. With the DMK, a key ally of the Congress-led UPA Government at the Centre, threatening to have its MPs resign from Parliament and ministers quit the Union Cabinet, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh acted swiftly to quell the crisis. He called up Rajapakse and gave him an earful about human rights violations of Sri Lankan Tamils and also about Indian fishermen near the Gulf at Mannar being shot at by the Sri Lankan Navy. While not calling for a ceasefire, he reiterated India's stand that there is no military solution to the ethnic crisis and that Rajapakse's Government must come up with a credible political process.

Rajapakse though is sticking to his stand

MOUNTING NUMBERS: An LTTE graveyard near Mallawi in the North



that he needs to continue the military operations against the LTTE and will not agree to a ceasefire. He maintains that a political solution would emerge once Prabhakaran is defeated. As an example of his sincerity he points to the East where he claims to have restored the democratic process. He also states that he has convened an all-party committee consisting of the major Sinhala parties to go into the question of devolution of powers to the Tamils. The committee though has run into trouble with the United National Party, the main Opposition party, pulling out of the talks.

Meanwhile, the pro-LTTE Sri Lankan

Tamil MPs have been as critical of the way Rajapakse's Government has been conducting the war. R. Sampanthan, an MP and parliamentary leader of the Tamil National Alliance party, says that the all-party committee is "a charade and a hoax". He says, "The Government is intent on seeking a purely military solution. This war is against the legitimate rights of the Tamil people. The Government has never come up with a set of proposals that can constitute a political challenge to the LTTE." He is critical of Rajapakse's showcasing the East saying, "The province doesn't enjoy the powers as that of an Indian state like Tamil Nadu or for that matter a Union Territory of India. There is no autonomy or devolution of powers. The provincial government is a puppet in the hands of the Sri Lankan Government."

India, which so far had nuanced its policy in Sri Lanka, is forced to make a strategic return into its affairs after the Tamil Nadu fallout. After the failure of the 1987 Indo-Sri Lankan Accord and with the Indian Peace Keeping Force being asked to leave in 1990, India has been averse to intervene militarily again in Sri Lanka's civil war. It has refrained from selling arms to the Government, though of late it has assisted with intelligence and the supply of radars. Initially, the Indian Government allowed Rajapakse to conduct war in the North with a relatively free hand as it looked upon the LTTE as a terrorist organisation which, among other things, had assassinated Rajiv Gandhi. But now India is pressuring Rajapakse to come up with a parallel political process that would work for genuine autonomy for the Tamils.

While Rajapakse continues to have the support of the Sinhala majority, despite inflation being over 25 per cent, he is unlikely to let up on the military operations. But if the war drags on till mid next year and casualties mount, then his Government would begin to feel the heat. Prabhakaran knows that and has deliberately slowed down the pace of the battle. He is now biding his time. In the past he has bounced back after being in a seemingly helpless position. But this time he is being confronted by a resolute Sri Lankan Government and an army whose morale is high and tactics that match his if not better than them.

Prabhakaran has never been in a situation as tight as this and is going to find it difficult to come out of the corner that he finds himself in. ■

If the war drags on and army casualties mount then Rajapakse will feel the heat. Prabhakaran knows this and is biding time.